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# The Conversational Analysis Method

## A Qualitative Research Guide

# How to interrogate data without coding line-by-line

You have likely been told that rigor requires suffering.

If you are a qualitative researcher, you know the script. You are expected to sit alone with 600 pages of transcripts. You are expected to read every line, highlight every relevant phrase, and tag it with a code. You do this until your eyes blur and your brain feels like it is leaking out of your ears.

We tell ourselves this drudgery is necessary. We believe that if we don't touch every word manually, we aren't doing "real" research.

But that is a trap.

The problem with manual coding is cognitive overload. By the time you have coded the fiftieth interview, you are often too exhausted to actually think about what the data means. You lose the forest for the trees.

On the other side, we have the "lazy" alternative. People dump ten transcripts into ChatGPT and ask for a summary. The result is usually vague, superficial, or hallucinated. It gives you an answer, but you have no idea how it got there. You cannot defend it. You cannot trace it. It is a black box.

There is a third option.

We call it Conversational Analysis with AI (CA to the power of AI).
In this method, you do not code. You interview your data. You treat the AI not as an oracle that gives you the final answer, but as a research assistant that retrieves evidence so you can do the thinking.

This guide explains exactly how to do it.

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# Phase 0: The Setup

## Garbage in, chaos out.

Large language models do not infer intent from data alone. Uploading transcripts or documents does not tell the model what the project is about. There is no background knowledge, no shared understanding, and no implicit research goal.

Many people assume that an LLM will “figure it out” once the data is there. That assumption leads to vague, generic, or misaligned outputs. Not because the model is weak, but because the analytic frame was never made explicit.

An LLM does not know what you are looking for unless you tell it. When you upload your data to QInsights, you must provide context. This description is sent along with every single query you ask.

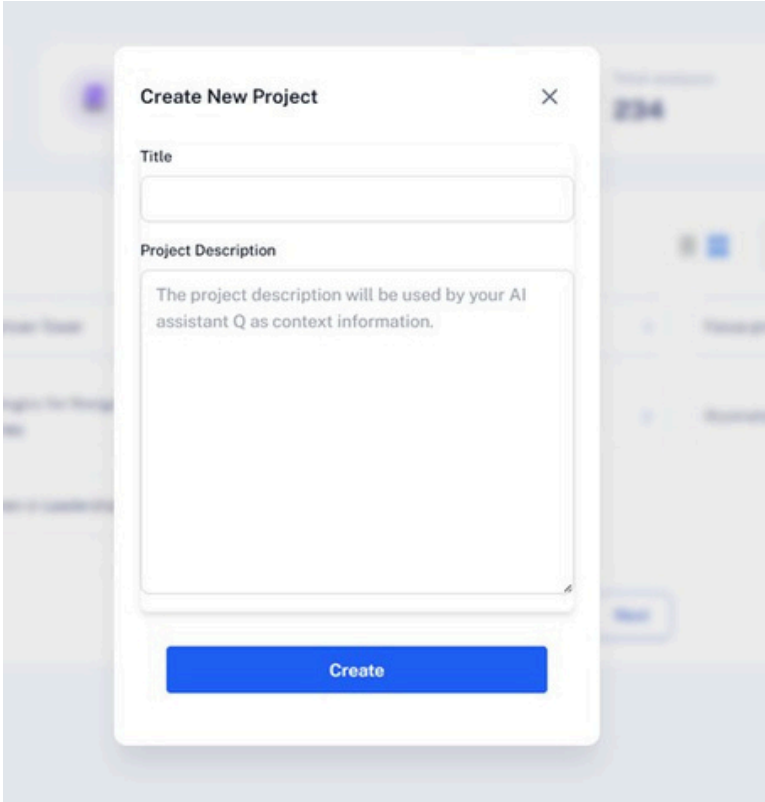


Figure 1: Creating a project in QInsights

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**Write a real description.** It should be between half a page and two pages. Imagine you are handing this project to a brilliant colleague who knows nothing about your specific study. What do they need to know to be helpful?

- What is the aim of the research?
- Who are the respondents?
- How was the data collected?
- What are the core research questions?

If you give the AI a two-liner, you will get generic answers. If you give it context, you get analysis.

**The Privacy Check**
Before you upload anything, you need to clear this with your ethics board. When using QInsights, this is how you can explain the data processing:

*"The data is processed on European Servers, compliant with GDPR. The data belongs to the user alone, is not used for LLM training, and no one apart from the user has access to it. The server uses double encryption for extra security."*

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# Phase 1: Getting Familiar

## The 10,000-foot view

Once your data is in, your first instinct will be to ask: "What are the main themes?"

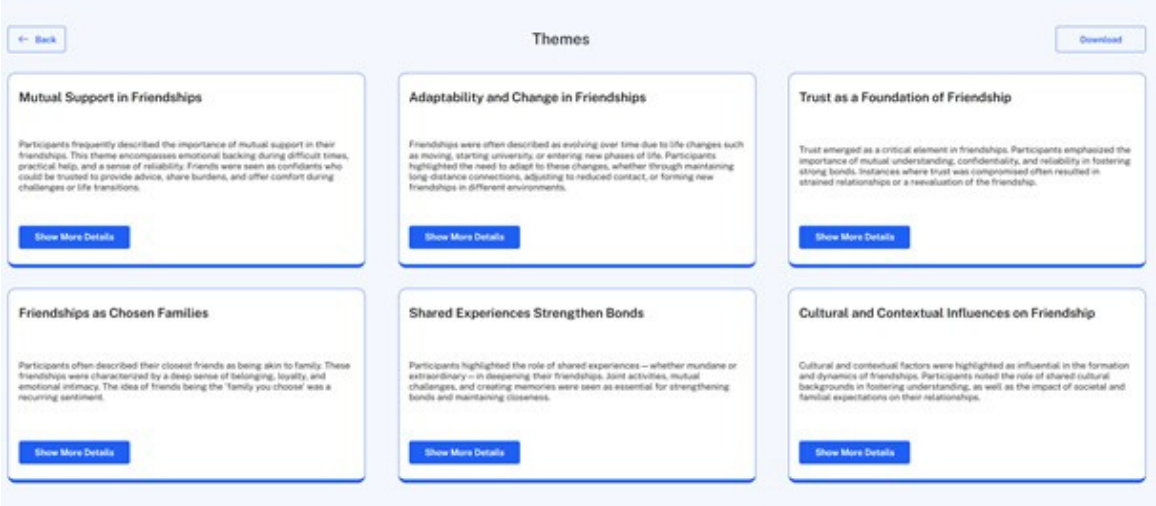
This is fine, but you must treat the output correctly. A list of themes generated by AI is not a result. It is a starting point. It is a map of where you might want to go.

## The Temperature Setting

At QInsights, we set the AI "temperature" to 0.2.

At 0.0, the model is highly deterministic: responses are repeatable but can become rigid and insensitive to linguistic nuance. At higher values, outputs become more variable. This can be useful for generative tasks, but in analytic contexts it increases the risk of drifting beyond what is supported by the data.

A temperature of 0.2 prioritises stability while retaining limited flexibility. This allows the model to surface patterns in the data without inventing content or over-interpreting isolated fragments.



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# Phase 1: Getting Familiar

## The Rule of Three

Because the AI has this slight variability, you should run the theme analysis three times.

- **Do not look for a perfect match.**
- **Look for the overlap.**

If a theme shows up in all three runs, it is likely robust. If a theme shows up only once, it might be a fringe idea. That doesn't mean it's wrong—fringe themes are often where the most interesting insights hide—but it requires your judgment to decide if it's worth following.

## Traceability is Non-Negotiable

Never accept a theme just because the screen says so. Click the reference. Read the source text. If the quote doesn't support the theme, reject it. You are the methodologist. The AI is just the sorter.

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# Phase 2: The Interrogation

## Stop coding. Start asking

In traditional analysis, you read a paragraph and tag it "Mental Health." In Conversational Analysis, you ask the data: “How do respondents define mental health.” Or later in the analysis: *"What strategies do speakers mention for maintaining mental health?"*

**This is where beginners fail. They ask one broad question and expect a final result.**

If your first prompt is, *“Based on the strategies people use to maintain mental health, what recommendations can we draw from the data?”*, you are asking the model to conclude before the analysis has begun. The LLM will happily oblige. It will generate a smooth, confident answer. But that is the trap. You will have no idea how it got there. You have effectively outsourced your thinking to a Black Box.

To maintain rigor, you must stay **inside the loop.** Build the analysis step-by-step. Start with descriptive questions to establish the facts: *How is X defined? Who is involved? In what contexts do these problems appear?*

Only once you have established the *what* do you move to the *why*. Descriptive first. Analytic second. Concluding last.

You need a **Question Protocol.** For every topic you want to explore, plan to ask 3 to 5 specific, descriptive questions. You ask them one by one.

### Example Protocol:

1. "What do respondents say about time managment?"
2. "What specific challenges do they mention regarding time management?"
3. "What responses or strategies do speakers describe in relation to these challenges"
4. "Who did not mention time management issues?" (Yes, the AI can handle negative evidence).

By the time you get the answers to these four questions, you have a deep, triangulated understanding of that topic across your documents.

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# Phase 2: The Interrogation

## The Comparison Table Hack

One of the most powerful things you can do is force the AI to structure its output. Instead of getting paragraphs of text, ask for a grid. This replaces the old "matrix analysis" we used to do by hand.

Use this exact prompt structure:
*"Create a table with respondent names in the columns across the top, and the [perspective on Topic X] in the rows.*

*In the cells, indicate with an X if the topic was mentioned.*
*In the cells, include a supporting quote if the topic is applicable.*
*In the cells, specify [sentiment/keyword]."*

Now you have a side-by-side comparison of every participant, with proof.

**Similarities and Differences in Friendship Journeys:**

| Aspect | Alexander | Trevor | Deborah | Shazia |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Initial Meeting | Met in history class after moving to England | Met at the gym where Trevor worked | Met in a university class | Met at age six after her friend moved from Germany |
| First Impressions | Welcoming and supportive | Positive, evolved into a brotherly bond | Positive, connected over shared motherhood | Intrigued by her friend's English skills |
| Shared Interests | School activities, football, traveling | Fitness, social outings | Motherhood, university studies | Learning languages, schoolwork |
| Activities | School discos, pub visits, traveling | Golf, pool, barbecues | Drinks, dinners, planning trips | Swimming, watching films, clubbing |
| Emotional Moments | Support during adjustment to new school | Support during illness | Support in balancing university and motherhood | Mutual support in personal milestones |
| Barriers | Cultural adjustment, bullying | Illness and job loss | Distance between homes | Initial worry about growing apart |
| Facilitators | Shared activities, mutual support | Mutual support, shared history | Shared motherhood experiences | Mutual learning and support |

References

Shazia.docx Trevor.docx Deborah.docx Alexander.docx

Figure 2: Synthesis at the end of a conversation

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# Phase 2: The Interrogation

## The "3-5 Document" Rule

Do not load dozens of interviews into the analysis at once. When the analytic scope becomes too broad, the model is forced to generalise. The result is not wrong, but abstract, flattened, and low in analytic resolution.

This is not a technical limitation in the narrow sense. Even with large context windows and selective retrieval, an AI asked to respond across too much material will summarise rather than analyse in depth.

Qualitative research has never been about scale. It is about depth. **A productive starting point is a small, coherent subset—typically 3 to 5 documents.** Analyse these closely first. Then move to the next batch, comparing and extending what you have already learned.

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# Optional Phase 3: The "Scar" Technique

## Applying Reflexive Analyses Techiques

Most people use AI to summarize what is on the page. But qualitative research is about interpreting what is behind the page.

We call this the "Scar" technique, based on a project where a PhD student said: "A PhD will leave a scar on your soul."  You can watch a full walk-through here.

If you just code that as "Negative Emotion," you miss the depth. We want to use the AI to do "Open Coding" or conceptual brainstorming.

### Step 1: Take it outside the data.

First, we ask the LLM to brainstorm the concept generally. We explicitly tell it to ignore our transcripts for a moment.

*Prompt:*
*"Let's take this outside the documents we are analyzing. On a general level, where can we encounter the word 'scar' and what are the possible meanings? From a physical wound to a scar in the heart after a breakup."*

The LLM will give you contexts: Physical (trauma), Emotional (grief), Environmental (landscape damage), Metaphorical (resilience), Literary or Artistic Context, Medical or Scientific context, etc., and a short description of each.

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# Optional Phase 3: The "Scar" Technique

## Step 2 :

Select contexts you want to explore further and ask for conditions, strategies and consequences (typical Grounded Theory questions).

## Step 3 :

Make far-out comparisons as brainstorming exercises. What have a scar and a carrot in common? Think of something wild, you will be surprised what you can learn from such a comparison and an LLM is your perfect sparring partner for it. Here is an example outcome. It will leave you with lots to think about.

### 1) Protective boundary

- Scar: new “skin” that seals and protects after injury.
- Carrot: skin/peel as boundary; can protect, can be removed.
- Properties/dimensions: thin → thick, flexible → rigid, smooth → rough.

### 2) Transformation through disruption

- Scar: tissue reorganizes after a break.
- Carrot: grows by reorganizing energy into a storage root (often shaped by soil resistance).
- Dimensions: sudden disruption (wound) ↔ slow pressure (soil/conditions).

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# Optional Phase 3: The "Scar" Technique

## Step 4: Develop concepts

Look across the answers from Steps 2 and 3 and ask what they point to conceptually.

Experienced researchers often recognise these patterns intuitively. If you are less experienced, you can ask the AI to help articulate them. Be explicit about what you want.

Based on the example we used here, we can derive concepts like: overcoming challenges, resilience, personal growth, endurance, or lasting impact.

This back-and-forth is all part of the analytic work. You are sharpening the concepts and defining what they do—and do not—capture.

## Step 5: Contrast and refine the concepts

Now you test the boundaries of the emerging concepts. Ask the AI to compare them explicitly:

- “How does resilience differ from coping in these transcripts?”
- “Where does personal growth appear, and where does it not?”
- “Which concepts seem to overlap, and which are clearly distinct?”

This step prevents premature closure. Concepts that initially appear similar often serve different analytic functions once contrasted.

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# Optional Phase 3: The "Scar" Technique

## Step 6: Anchor concepts in the data

Finally, you force every concept back into the material. For each concept, ask:

- *“Which passages best illustrate this concept?”*
- *“Where is this concept absent, despite being theoretically plausible?”*
- *“Which participants challenge or complicate this concept?”*

At this point, concepts are no longer speculative. They are grounded, bounded, and defensible.

This is the transition from exploratory interpretation to analytic synthesis. You are not yet drawing conclusions or making recommendations. You are establishing the conceptual building blocks that make those later steps possible.

## A note on friction (the “stubborn teenager” effect)

At times, the LLM will not respond in the way you expect. It may stay descriptive when you asked for concepts, repeat an earlier answer, or misunderstand the analytic move you are trying to make. This can happen.

Treat these moments as part of the interaction, not as an error. Clarify what you need. Narrow the instruction. Ask again, more precisely.

Conversational Analysis assumes iteration. The analyst stays in control and corrects the direction when needed.

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# Phase 4: Synthesis and Defense

## Rigor comes from traceability

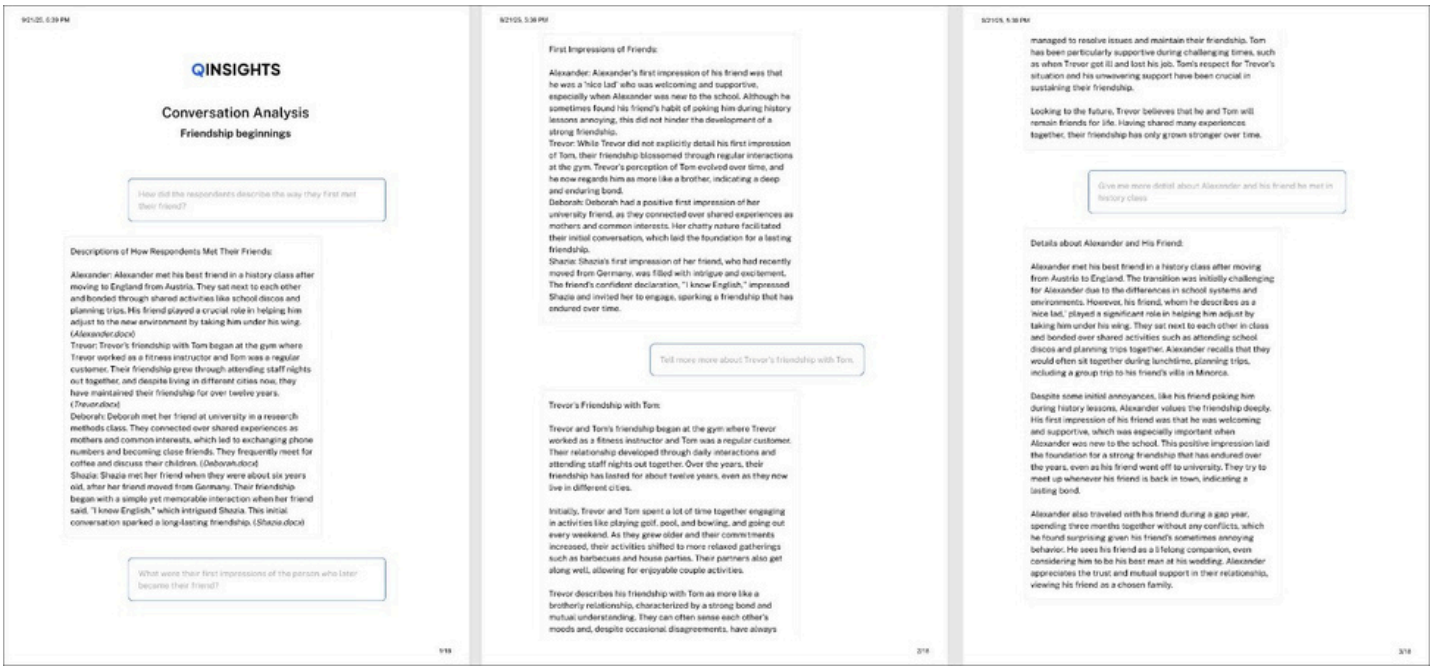
The biggest fear researchers have is the "Black Box." They worry that if they use AI, they won't be able to defend their work to a supervisor or a review board.

The opposite is true.

When you code manually, your logic is often hidden inside your own head. Why did you tag that paragraph? You might not remember three months later.

In Conversational Analysis, you have a perfect audit trail.

1. **The Chat Protocol:** You can export the entire conversation. Every question you asked and every answer the AI gave is recorded.



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Conversation Analysis

Friendship beginnings

How did the respondents describe the way they first met their friend?

Descriptions of How Respondents Met Their Friends:

Alexander: Alexander met his best friend in a history class after moving to England from Austria. They sat next to each other and bonded through shared activities like school discos and planning trips. His friend played a crucial role in helping him adjust to the new environment by taking him under his wing. (*Alexander.docx*)
Trevor: Trevor's friendship with Tom began at the gym where Trevor worked as a fitness instructor and Tom was a regular customer. Their friendship grew through attending staff nights out together, and despite living in different cities now, they have maintained their friendship for over twelve years. (*Trevor.docx*)
Deborah: Deborah met her friend at university in a research methods class. They connected over shared experiences as mothers and common interests, which led to exchanging phone numbers and becoming close friends. They frequently meet for coffee and discuss their children. (*Deborah.docx*)
Shazia: Shazia met her friend when they were about six years old, after her friend moved from Germany. Their friendship began with a simple yet memorable interaction when her friend said, "I know English," which intrigued Shazia. This initial conversation sparked a long-lasting friendship. (*Shazia.docx*)

What were their first impressions of the person who later became their friend?

First Impressions of Friends:

Alexander: Alexander's first impression of his friend was that he was a 'nice lad' who was welcoming and supportive, especially when Alexander was new to the school. Although he sometimes found his friend's habit of poking him during history lessons annoying, this did not hinder the development of a strong friendship.
Trevor: While Trevor did not explicitly detail his first impression of Tom, their friendship blossomed through regular interactions at the gym. Trevor's perception of Tom evolved over time, and he now regards him as more like a brother, indicating a deep and enduring bond.
Deborah: Deborah had a positive first impression of her university friend, as they connected over shared experiences as mothers and common interests. Her chatty nature facilitated their initial conversation, which laid the foundation for a lasting friendship.
Shazia: Shazia's first impression of her friend, who had recently moved from Germany, was filled with intrigue and excitement. The friend's confident declaration, "I know English," impressed Shazia and invited her to engage, sparking a friendship that has endured over time.

Tell more more about Trevor's friendship with Tom.

Trevor's Friendship with Tom:

Trevor and Tom's friendship began at the gym where Trevor worked as a fitness instructor and Tom was a regular customer. Their relationship developed through daily interactions and attending staff nights out together. Over the years, their friendship has lasted for about twelve years, even as they now live in different cities.

Initially, Trevor and Tom spent a lot of time together engaging in activities like playing golf, pool, and bowling, and going out every weekend. As they grew older and their commitments increased, their activities shifted to more relaxed gatherings such as barbecues and house parties. Their partners also get along well, allowing for enjoyable couple activities.

Trevor describes his friendship with Tom as more like a brotherly relationship, characterized by a strong bond and mutual understanding. They can often sense each other's moods and, despite occasional disagreements, have always managed to resolve issues and maintain their friendship. Tom has been particularly supportive during challenging times, such as when Trevor got ill and lost his job. Tom's respect for Trevor's situation and his unwavering support have been crucial in sustaining their friendship.

Looking to the future, Trevor believes that he and Tom will remain friends for life. Having shared many experiences together, their friendship has only grown stronger over time.

Give me more detail about Alexander and his friend he met in history class

Details about Alexander and His Friend:

Alexander met his best friend in a history class after moving from Austria to England. The transition was initially challenging for Alexander due to the differences in school systems and environments. However, his friend, whom he describes as a 'nice lad,' played a significant role in helping him adjust by taking him under his wing. They sat next to each other in class and bonded over shared activities such as attending school discos and planning trips together. Alexander recalls that they would often sit together during lunchtime, planning trips, including a group trip to his friend's villa in Minorca.

Despite some initial annoyances, like his friend poking him during history lessons, Alexander values the friendship deeply. His first impression of his friend was that he was welcoming and supportive, which was especially important when Alexander was new to the school. This positive impression laid the foundation for a strong friendship that has endured over the years, even as his friend went off to university. They try to meet up whenever his friend is back in town, indicating a lasting bond.

Alexander also traveled with his friend during a gap year, spending three months together without any conflicts, which he found surprising given his friend's sometimes annoying behavior. He sees his friend as a lifelong companion, even considering him to be his best man at his wedding. Alexander appreciates the trust and mutual support in their relationship, viewing his friend as a chosen family.

Figure 3: Chat protocoll

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# Phase 4: Synthesis and Defense

2. **The Question Set:** You can publish your list of questions. This allows other researchers to replicate your analysis.

3. **The References:** Every claim is linked to one or more data segments.

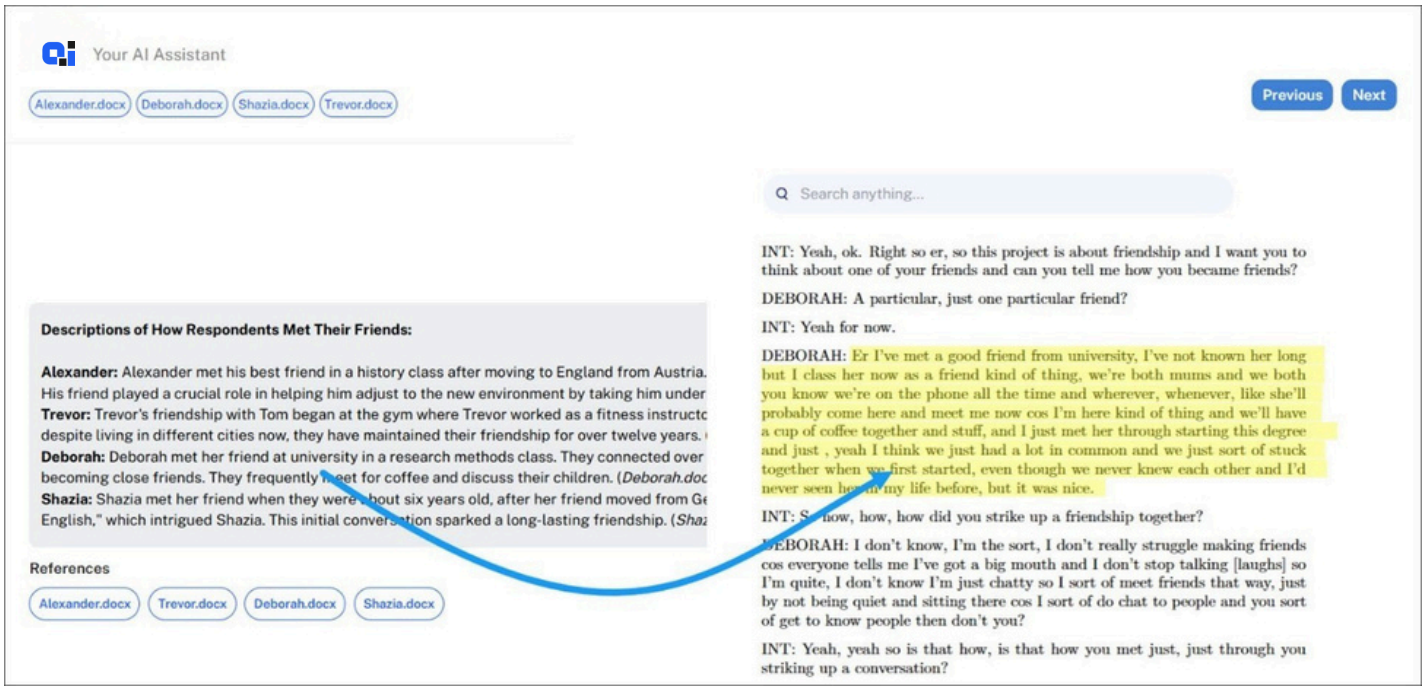


Figure 4: AI answers can be traced to the original source files

**Visualizing the Output** Currently, in QInsights the AI cannot draw a diagram for you. But it can describe one.

Ask it: "Based on these answers, how would you visualize the relationship between [Topic A] and [Topic B]? Is one a prerequisite for the other?" It will describe the relationships (e.g., "Self-reliance appears to be the core category that drives Motivation"). You can then draw that map yourself.

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# Phase 4: Synthesis and Defense

Figure 5: Image created based on the description the AI-assistant has provided

## Writing the Report

When you write your methodology section, do not hide the tool. Cite the method. Current options are (See Literature below):

- Conversational Analysis with AI
- Query-Based Analysis
- Narrative-Integrated Thematic Analysis

And there will probably more developed in the future.

You are not claiming the AI did the work. You are claiming that you used a structured, query-based method to interrogate the data.

# Summary

The goal of this method is not to speed up the process so you can do less work. The goal is to offload the mechanical retrieval of information so you can do better work.

You stop wasting your brain power on searching for quotes. You start spending your brain power on deciding what those quotes mean.

**Next Step**: Try it on a small scale. Take 3 of your own transcripts. Upload them to the QInsights trial version. It gives you enough tokens to do this for free.

Write a proper project description. Ask three specific questions. See if you don't learn more in 20 minutes of conversation than you would have in three days of highlighting.

## Literature

Nguyen-Trung, K., & Nguyen, N. L. (2025, March 4). Narrative-Integrated Thematic Analysis (NITA): How can LLMs support theme generation without coding? *SSRN*, http://dx.doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.5163884

Morgan D. L. (2025) Query-Based Analysis (QBA): A Strategy for Analyzing Qualitative Data Using ChatGPT. *Qualitative Health Research*. 2025; 0(0). doi:10.1177/10497323251321712

Friese, S. (2026, forthcomig). Conversational Analysis with AI - CA to the Power of AI: Rethinking Coding in Qualitative Analysis. *Qualitative Inquiry*. (Preprint: April 27, 2025). http://dx.doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.5232579